

Configuration and secrets

Project: Grounded Learning Service

1. Your mission

Your learning target

I can explain the mechanism and terminology of configuration and secrets.

I can apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result.

I can identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up.

Remember before reading

Close your notes first. A rough first answer helps us choose the right starting point; it is not a score for your ability.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Typed contracts and schemas. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Requirements and service boundaries. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

After trying, check the relevant lesson or ask your teacher. Change the part of your explanation that the evidence shows was wrong.

This week you will practise:

Explain the mechanism and terminology of configuration and secrets

Apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result

Identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up

Retrieve what you already know

Recall Typed contracts and schemas. Explain why a recorded result needs its input conditions and evidence source before it can support a claim.

My starting explanation

This week's end goal

Explain configuration and secrets using the deciding step in this fictional service.

2. Notice the evidence

Configuration supplies non-secret settings; secrets provide privileged values. Keep secrets out of source, logs and client responses.

Begin by writing the question the procedure is intended to answer. Identify the information already supplied, the information it will produce and the information still missing. These are constructed classroom examples; they do not require live accounts, private records or an external service. Do not treat a plausible explanation as a measured outcome.

List the given facts and one fact that is not supplied.

3. See how it works

The toy service reads DATA_VERSION from configuration and a signing secret from server-only input. Validate required settings at startup and fail clearly if absent; do not substitute a published default secret.

Configuration and secrets — evidence trace

Input and scope · Check or calculation · Conclusion and limit

Input and scope: A startup script prints every environment variable while debugging a missing data version.

Check or calculation: The toy service reads DATA_VERSION from configuration and a signing secret from server-only input. Validate required settings at startup and fail clearly if absent; do not substitute a published default secret.

Conclusion and limit: It risks exposing secrets unrelated to the error. Report the missing key name without values and validate only required fields.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Before applying the procedure, write its units, denominator or decision boundary where relevant. A partner should be able to repeat each step using the same inputs. If a required input is absent or violates the stated contract, record that condition explicitly instead of quietly replacing it with a convenient value.

Connect the picture and the explanation

Point to the input, the deciding step and the result in this week's visual. Explain the same step in ordinary words. A picture helps when you can say what each part represents.

4. Compare the cases

Compare a familiar case with a changed case

A startup script prints every environment variable while debugging a missing data version. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Keep the procedure fixed. Explain what changed in the inputs and result.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change: Change maximum_words to 60.

Prediction: The configured answer limit becomes 60; the private token stays unchanged.

Reason: An ordinary length setting does not require replacing the credential.

5. Words that unlock the idea

Word · Meaning

Word: Secret

Meaning: A value whose disclosure can grant privileged access

Word: Configuration

Meaning: Declared settings controlling operation

Word: Redaction

Meaning: Removing sensitive values from displayed or recorded output

Use two terms to explain a step in this week's example.

6. Follow a worked example

A startup script prints every environment variable while debugging a missing data version.

It risks exposing secrets unrelated to the error. Report the missing key name without values and validate only required fields.

Compare the intermediate evidence with the final statement. Explain why each number or decision follows from the stated inputs. The conclusion belongs to this scenario and procedure; changing the inputs, evaluation population or authority can change what it establishes. Retain the raw record so a later revision can be compared honestly.

Learn from the worked case

Cover the result before checking it. Say what is given, choose the procedure, and follow one step at a time. Then uncover the result and explain your first mismatch. Ask why a step is allowed, not only what number it produces.

A pictorial worked case: Configuration and secrets

Settings and a sealed credential. A classroom bot needs a public answer-length setting and a private access token.

The facts we will use

`maximum_words=80` is public configuration. A separate protected store holds a placeholder credential.

Configuration and secrets

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Load setting

Read the reviewed maximum_words value of 80.



2. Load credential

The runtime obtains the token through its protected path.



3. Log safely

Record startup success without printing the token.

CHANGE ONE THING

Change maximum_words to 60.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Read the picture one step at a time

Step · What happens and why

Step: 1. Load setting

What happens and why: Read the reviewed maximum_words value of 80.

Step: 2. Load credential

What happens and why: The runtime obtains the token through its protected path.

Step: 3. Log safely

What happens and why: Record startup success without printing the token.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

Configuration controls behaviour. A credential grants access and needs different storage and handling.

What this example does not establish

Protected storage alone cannot prevent leaks through logs, screenshots or excessive runtime permissions.

7. Find and repair a mistake

A classroom mock is not a production credential-management design; no real secrets are needed here.

A useful check asks what would make the reasoning fail. Distinguish a failure to execute the declared procedure from a weakness in the procedure itself. The first may require a correction; the second requires an explicitly revised method and new evidence. Preserve unsuccessful cases so an improved result cannot hide the original problem.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Locate the earliest unsupported step

A report omits this qualification: A classroom mock is not a production credential-management design; no real secrets are needed here. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

State one repair and the checks you would rerun.

8. Practise together

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Explain your prediction to a partner before comparing results.

Practise with less help: Trace the worked case

Use workbook W2 for the connected example “Configuration and secrets”. First fill the input and rule boxes. Try the middle steps before asking for a hint. After a hint, try the next step yourself.

Plan · Do · Check

Plan: What is given? Which rule or procedure applies?

Do: Record each intermediate step.

Check: Does the result follow? What remains unknown?

Explain your trace to a partner. Your partner points to one step to check. Swap roles on the next case.

Each person writes their own explanation.

Check your reasoning

Use the worked case for Configuration and secrets. Proposed explanation: “The worked result establishes every future case”. Decide whether this explanation is supported. Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Answer on your own before discussion. If you are unsure, say which step you need help with.

Explain the picture

Point to the public setting and the protected credential. What changes when maximum_words becomes 60, and which information must never appear in the startup log?

My explanation using a pictured step and the given facts

This is supported practice. Keep the separately named independent case for an attempt before feedback.

9. Run the investigation

Predict, investigate and preserve the evidence

A startup script prints every environment variable while debugging a missing data version. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Record · Your evidence

Record: Given input and fixed rule

Your evidence: _____

Record: Prediction before checking

Your evidence: _____

Record: Actual result, or “not run”

Your evidence: _____

Record: First mismatch and one explanation

Your evidence: _____

Record: Boundary or missing input and expected response

Your evidence: _____

On paper, trace the supplied procedure. If code is provided, predict before running it in a local practice file. Never write an expected answer as though it were an observed run.

Plan → try → check

Before trying: what do I expect, and why? While trying: which step could first go wrong? Afterwards: what did I actually observe, and what should change? Keep “not run” if you only traced the procedure.

10. Build your understanding

Explain → apply → challenge

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

A report omits this qualification: A classroom mock is not a production credential-management design; no real secrets are needed here. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

Explain which evidence supports your conclusion and which claim remains unproved.

11. Connect your project

Add a labelled configuration and secrets evidence sheet to Grounded Learning Service. Show how you can explain the mechanism and terminology of configuration and secrets. Use the supplied fictional case and keep its inputs, intermediate steps, calculation or prediction, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Project evidence · Record

Project evidence: Component and version

Record: _____

Project evidence: Inputs permitted at prediction time

Record: _____

Project evidence: Trace and comparison with earlier work

Record: _____

Project evidence: Failure, limit and human review

Record: _____

Evidence for your project

For the Grounded Learning Service, retain an annotated trace and the changed-case result. Name the contract or evidence that makes the deciding step valid, so another team can review it.

12. Show what you know

Complete the supported workbook tasks before attempting W4 independently. Record any hints or help used. After feedback, use the teacher's fresh retry rather than copying the earlier answer. For a project, select a relevant new case, predict the outcome from the declared rule and preserve the result alongside any revision.

Exit: propose one revealing change to the worked scenario. State the expected outcome and the evidence that would make you revise your explanation.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

My limited claim and a useful next check

13. Study a complete case

Complete evidence record

Configuration and secrets — evidence trace

Input and scope · Check or calculation · Conclusion and limit

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The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Follow the input through the stated procedure to its result. Cover the result first, predict it, then explain every intermediate step. The text/table accompanies the figure so the example can be read without colour.

My complete trace of the worked case

14. Try a new case independently

Independent case: Apply a new case independently

Server secret exists, but a browser error includes its full value. What failed and what record should be produced instead?

My independent explanation, trace and limits

Attempt this case before feedback. Record any help. Earlier examples below are further practice; a case already practised with feedback cannot establish fresh transfer.

Attempt this without hints

Server secret exists, but a browser error includes its full value. What failed and what record should be produced instead?

My independent procedure, result and limitation

Record support used: none, hint or teacher explanation. After feedback, a different case is needed to demonstrate independence.

Use feedback to improve

Attempt the independent case before hints. Record whether you worked alone, used a hint or followed a model. After feedback, fix the first unsupported step and explain why it changed. A later check uses a changed case, not a copied answer.